

**galaxy**

A large group of *stars*, dust, and gas held together by the *force* of *gravity*.

**gear**

One of a pair of wheels of different sizes, with teeth cut into their edges, that turn together to increase the speed or *force* of a machine.

**genetics**

The study of genes—the parts of a *cell* that control the growth and appearance of living things.

**geophysicist**

A physicist who studies Earth and its environment.

**global warming**

The rise in Earth's temperature that is affecting the world's weather, causing droughts and severe storms.

**gravity**

The *force* that attracts all objects. On Earth, it is responsible for making objects fall downward and for giving things weight.

**habitat**

The place where a plant or an animal normally lives.

**heredity**

The passing of characteristics through generations.

**hormone**

A *chemical* in the bloodstream that controls a function of the body.

**insulator**

A substance that reduces the flow of heat.

**Internet**

A network that allows computers across the world to exchange information.

**latitude**

Measurement of how far north or south an object is from the equator. The equator is an imaginary line that runs horizontally around the middle of Earth.

**lens**

A curved, transparent piece of plastic or glass that can bend light rays to make something look bigger, smaller, closer, or further away.

**lever**

A rod balanced on a pivot that can increase the size of a pushing, pulling, or turning *force*.

**light year**

The distance light travels in a year. One light year is about 6 trillion miles (9.5 trillion km).

**longitude**

Measurement of how far east or west of the Prime Meridian an object is. The Prime Meridian is an imaginary line that runs from the North Pole, via Greenwich, England, to the South Pole. Longitude lines run from north to south.

**magnetic field**

The invisible patterns of *force* that stretch around a magnet.

**magnetism**

A *force* that can attract or repel certain metals.

**mammals**

Warm-blooded vertebrates that give birth to young who feed on their mother's milk.

**mass**

The amount of *matter* that an object contains.

**matter**

The material which everything around us is made of.

**melting point**

The temperature at which a solid changes into a liquid.

**microbe**

A living thing that can be seen only through a microscope. *Bacteria* are the most common type of microbe. Also called microorganism.

**molecule**

The smallest amount of a

*compound*, consisting of two or more *atoms* bonded together.

**motor**

A machine that uses *electricity* and *magnetism* to produce spinning movement or movement in a straight line.

**neutron**

A subatomic particle with no electric charge found in an *atom's nucleus*.

**nucleus**

The central part of an *atom*, made of *protons* and *neutrons*.

**observatory**

A building from where astronomers study space.

**patent**

A government document that grants sole rights to a person to make, use, and/or sell an invention.

**pesticide**

A substance used to destroy insects and other pests of crop.

**philosophy**

The study of ideas such as knowledge, reality, nature and existence of life, and mind.

**photocell**

An electronic device that generates *electricity* using light.

**physics**

The study of science relating primarily to *energy* and *matter*. A physicist is a scientist who studies the relation between *matter* and *energy*.

**piston**

A round metal part that fits tightly inside a cylinder and moves back and forward.

**pollution**

Damage caused to the environment by dirty or poisonous substances or *chemicals*.

**protein**

A vital nutrient that helps the body build new *cells*.

**proton**

A subatomic particle with a positive charge found in an *atom's nucleus*.

**radiometric dating**

Measuring the amount of radioactive substances in an object to find out its age.

**radio waves**

A type of *energy* that travels in waves, and can be used to send information, especially sound.

**reproduction**

The process of creating offspring.

**solar system**

The region of space that includes the Sun, the planets and their moons, and other bodies in space whose movements are affected by the Sun's *gravity*.

**species**

A group of organisms that look alike and can breed mainly with one another.

**star**

A celestial body that releases *energy* from the nuclear reactions in its core.

**theory**

An explanation of facts or phenomena based on observation or experiments.

**vaccine**

Precautionary medical treatment that stops an individual from contracting a disease.

**vacuum**

An empty space from where air and all other substances have been removed.

**viruses**

*Microbes* that multiply by infecting living *cells*, often causing disease.

**vitamin**

A *chemical compound* that the body needs for growth and development.